

Artificial Intelligence Did Not Break Education: How Generative AI Exposed a Pre-existing Crisis of Purpose in Higher Education

Abstract

The emergence of generative artificial intelligence tools within higher education has prompted widespread institutional concern centred primarily on academic integrity and the detection of AI-generated work. This article argues that such responses are fundamentally misdirected. Drawing on the educational philosophies of John Dewey, Richard Sennett, Martha Nussbaum and Ron Barnett, and the cultural criticism of Stefan Collini, the article contends that artificial intelligence has not created a new crisis in higher education but has rendered visible a pre-existing one: the gradual displacement of genuine intellectual formation by the performance of learning. The article examines how audit culture, declining studio and contact time, and assessment practices oriented towards the evaluation of outputs rather than processes created the conditions that make AI-assisted submission both rational and difficult to prevent. It further argues that students who resort to generative tools before developing the intellectual foundations necessary to use them critically are not merely producing poor work but are being deprived of formative developmental experience. The article concludes that an adequate response to the AI moment requires not the refinement of detection mechanisms but institutional courage: a willingness to rebuild educational practice from its foundational purposes, centred on the formation of thinking, judging and responsible human beings.

Keywords: artificial intelligence; higher education; academic integrity; educational purpose; formative learning; audit culture; design education; curriculum renewal

INTRODUCTION

The arrival of generative artificial intelligence tools in higher education has produced a reaction that is, in its broad contours, familiar to anyone who has observed institutional responses to previous technological disruptions. Committees have been convened. Policies have been revised. Software designed to detect AI-generated text has been evaluated and, in many cases, deployed. The central preoccupation of much institutional governance has become one of identification: how to determine whether a piece of submitted work was produced by the student whose name it bears, or by a machine acting on rudimentary instructions.

This article does not dismiss these concerns. Academic integrity is a genuine and serious matter, and the ease with which generative AI tools can produce plausible academic prose has created real difficulties for conventional assessment practice. However, the article argues that the dominant institutional response fundamentally misidentifies the nature of the crisis. In treating the AI moment primarily as an integrity problem, universities have deflected attention from a more uncomfortable question: whether the practices that generative AI has disrupted were adequately serving the purposes of education in the first place.

The argument proceeds as follows. The first section examines the conditions within higher education, and art and design education in particular, that preceded the widespread availability of generative AI and that created the context in which its misuse has become both widespread and rational. The second section analyses the specific character of AI-assisted student work and what it reveals about prevailing assessment culture. The third section draws on philosophical and educational theory to articulate what has been lost, and what is at stake, when the performance of learning is permitted to substitute for learning itself. The fourth section considers the implications for students who encounter powerful generative tools before developing the intellectual

foundations necessary to use them critically. The fifth section examines the limits of detection-centred institutional responses. The article concludes with a consideration of what a genuine response to the AI moment might require.

THE CONDITIONS THAT PRECEDED THE CRISIS

To understand the AI moment in higher education, it is necessary to begin not with the technology but with the institutional and pedagogical conditions into which it arrived. Those conditions had been deteriorating, unevenly and largely without public acknowledgement, for at least two decades.

In art and design education, the effects of this deterioration were particularly visible. The studio has historically been the defining environment of creative formation: a space in which students develop ideas through sustained making, encounter failure as a productive condition, and gradually internalise the intellectual and technical habits of a discipline.¹ Over recent years, however, the studio as a genuine site of extended engagement has been under significant pressure. Contact hours have been reduced. Buildings have been subject to rationalised opening times that reflect administrative priorities rather than the irregular rhythms of creative work. A growing proportion of students have been managing part-time employment alongside their studies, in many cases as a direct consequence of the financial conditions imposed by the expansion of tuition fees and the reduction of maintenance support.²

The result has been a quiet but significant erosion of the conditions under which serious learning can occur. Richard Sennett, writing on the relationship between craft, skill and human development, argues that the acquisition of genuine expertise requires not merely instruction but time: the unhurried repetition, the willingness to dwell with difficulty, and the experience of incremental mastery that together constitute the formative dimension of skilled practice.³ What

has been lost in many contemporary educational settings is precisely this temporal and environmental dimension. Students have been enrolled in programmes that gesture towards the development of professional and intellectual capacities whilst systematically denying them the conditions under which those capacities can be cultivated.

This erosion did not pass entirely unnoticed. Scholars such as Stefan Collini had for some years been arguing that the transformation of British universities under successive waves of market-oriented policy had involved a fundamental redefinition of educational purpose: from the cultivation of understanding to the production of qualified, employable graduates.⁴ The metrics of audit culture, including the National Student Survey, the Research Excellence Framework, and the Teaching Excellence Framework, had progressively reoriented institutional attention towards the measurement and demonstration of outcomes, with diminishing concern for the quality of the processes by which those outcomes were ostensibly achieved. In this context, the conditions conducive to genuine learning became, in institutional terms, increasingly difficult to justify.

THE PERFORMANCE OF LEARNING: WHAT AI-ASSISTED SUBMISSIONS REVEAL

When generative AI tools became widely accessible to students, the consequences for written academic work became rapidly apparent to those engaged in assessment. A characteristic type of submission began to appear with increasing frequency: technically accomplished in superficial respects, grammatically correct and appropriately registered, yet intellectually hollow. Such work floated above the specific question it purported to address, offered generalisations where argument was required, and exhibited none of the particular intellectual signature that genuine engagement with a problem tends to produce.

The immediate temptation is to read such submissions as evidence of a new form of dishonesty enabled by new technology. This reading is not entirely wrong. But it is incomplete. A

more searching analysis reveals that what AI-assisted submission makes visible is the extent to which educational systems had already accommodated the production of outputs that bore only a nominal relationship to genuine intellectual work. Students who generate essays using language models and submit them with minimal revision are doing something that is qualitatively distinct from, but structurally continuous with, what had already become common practice: the strategic production of work designed to satisfy assessment criteria rather than to articulate or deepen understanding.

This observation is not intended to excuse academic dishonesty. It is intended to locate it within a broader account of how assessment culture in higher education had developed. The educational theorist John Dewey argued, in his account of genuine learning, that it occurs through what he termed reflective experience: the disciplined engagement with real problems in which the learner must construct meaning through active inquiry.⁵ Assessment systems designed primarily to evaluate terminal outputs, rather than to make the process of inquiry visible and assessable, are necessarily impoverished as instruments of formation. They are also, as the AI moment has demonstrated, vulnerable to a particular kind of substitution.

When a machine can produce a plausible essay in seconds, the value of requiring students to produce plausible essays without one is difficult to articulate, unless the essay was never merely about the essay. Unless it was always, at its most significant, a record of a thinking process: evidence not simply of a conclusion reached but of the intellectual journey undertaken to reach it. The widespread adoption of AI-assisted submission has not introduced this problem. It has made a pre-existing problem impossible to ignore.

FORMATION, JUDGEMENT AND THE PURPOSES OF EDUCATION

The question of what higher education is for has never been easy to answer, and it would be unwise to suggest otherwise. Universities have historically served multiple purposes simultaneously: the transmission of disciplinary knowledge, the development of critical and creative capacities, the formation of professional identity, the cultivation of civic understanding, and the production of original research. These purposes are not always mutually compatible, and the tensions between them have been a persistent feature of educational debate.

Nevertheless, a thread runs through much of the serious philosophy of education that is relevant to the present discussion: the conviction that education is, at its most fundamental, a practice of human formation. Martha Nussbaum, arguing for the continuing importance of the humanities within higher education, contends that the primary purpose of a liberal education is to cultivate the human capacity for critical self-examination, for sympathetic engagement with perspectives other than one's own, and for the exercise of judgment in conditions of complexity and uncertainty.⁶ These capacities are not produced by the completion of assignments that can be adequately performed by a language model. They require challenge, failure, dialogue and the sustained experience of working at the edge of one's current understanding.

Ron Barnett, approaching the question from the perspective of higher education theory, has described the condition of the contemporary university as one of supercomplexity: a condition in which not merely the world but the frameworks by which we understand the world are in contest.⁷ In such a condition, he argues, the primary task of higher education is not the transmission of established knowledge but the formation of graduates capable of acting with judgment, responsibility and resilience in the face of radical uncertainty. This is a demanding educational ideal, and it stands in sharp contrast to the more modest aspiration of producing graduates who can demonstrate competence in a set of defined skills and knowledge domains.

The AI moment forces a confrontation between these two visions of educational purpose. If universities are fundamentally concerned with formation, then they must ask whether their current practices genuinely serve that purpose, and whether the conditions they provide are adequate to it. If they are concerned primarily with qualification, then they must accept that the efficiency with which generative AI can produce qualifying outputs represents not a crisis but a completion: the logical terminus of a trajectory that was already well advanced.

THE PREMATURE DELEGATION OF COGNITIVE WORK

A dimension of the AI crisis that has received insufficient attention in academic and policy debate concerns the developmental consequences for students who encounter generative tools before they have established the intellectual foundations that would allow them to use such tools productively. The issue here is not simply that such students produce work that is not their own. It is that, in delegating cognitive work to a machine at an early stage of their development, they are deprived of the formative experiences through which genuine intellectual capacity is built.

Sennett's account of craft development is instructive in this regard. He argues that the acquisition of skill involves a developmental sequence in which practitioners must first work slowly and consciously, making errors visible and submitting to correction, before the principles underlying their practice can become sufficiently internalised to permit fluent and inventive performance.⁸ A student who has never struggled to formulate an argument cannot recognise a weak argument when one is generated on their behalf. A student who has never worked through the difficulty of a design problem cannot evaluate the adequacy of solutions a generative tool proposes. The premature delegation of cognitive work does not merely bypass the process of learning. It actively forecloses it.

This observation has significant implications for the way in which generative AI might productively be integrated into educational practice at a later stage of development. There is nothing intrinsically incompatible between the use of powerful computational tools and the development of genuine expertise. Professionals in many fields use such tools effectively precisely because they have first developed the foundational knowledge and judgment that allow them to interrogate, evaluate and redirect the outputs those tools produce. The problem is not the technology. It is the timing of its introduction, and the absence of the intellectual foundations that would make its use critically productive rather than cognitively substitutive.

THE LIMITS OF DETECTION

The dominant institutional response to AI-assisted submission has been to invest in detection. Universities have adopted software platforms that purport to identify AI-generated text, have revised assessment formats to include more invigilated elements, and have updated academic integrity policies to address the new landscape. These measures are not without value. They signal institutional seriousness about academic integrity and may deter some students from submitting AI-generated work unreflectively.

However, the detection approach is limited in at least three significant respects. First, detection tools are imperfect and developing rapidly in ways that may favour generation over identification. The relationship between AI writing tools and AI detection tools has the character of an arms race in which the generative side has thus far shown greater adaptive capacity.⁹ Second, and more fundamentally, detection treats the symptom rather than the cause. A student who is deterred from submitting AI-generated work by fear of detection has not thereby been motivated to engage more deeply with their studies. The conditions that made AI substitution attractive

remain in place. Third, and most significantly, the focus on detection deflects institutional attention from the harder questions that the AI moment raises about the adequacy of educational practice.

An educational system in which students engage seriously with the work set for them because they understand its value to their own development is not primarily vulnerable to AI-assisted submission. Detection becomes a less urgent concern in proportion to the extent that education is genuinely formative. The converse is equally true: a system in which assessment is primarily experienced as a hurdle to be cleared will always be vulnerable to the most efficient available means of clearing it, whatever that means happens to be at any given moment.

CONCLUSION: RENEWAL RATHER THAN REPAIR

The argument of this article is that the crisis revealed by generative artificial intelligence in higher education is not primarily a technological crisis, nor primarily a crisis of academic integrity. It is a crisis of purpose: a forced confrontation with the question of what universities are for, and whether current practices adequately serve those purposes.

The response to this crisis cannot be detection alone, nor can it be the indefinite elaboration of integrity policies designed to manage the symptoms of a deeper institutional problem. What is required is something more demanding: a willingness to examine, honestly and without institutional self-interest, whether prevailing educational practices are genuinely developing the capacities they claim to develop, and a corresponding willingness to rebuild them where they are not.

In practice, this means investing in the conditions that make genuine learning possible: adequate time and space for sustained intellectual and creative engagement; assessment practices that make the process of thinking visible rather than merely evaluating its terminal products; teaching relationships of sufficient depth to support the development of individual voice and

judgment; and institutional cultures that value formation over throughput. It means, above all, resisting the metrics of audit culture that have progressively narrowed the educational horizon.

This is not a modest undertaking. It requires what might fairly be described as institutional courage: the willingness to acknowledge that the crisis exposed by artificial intelligence is not new, and that the response to it must therefore be deeper than any merely technical fix can provide. The clock on this reckoning has been running for longer than the technology suggests. What the technology has done is make it impossible, at last, to pretend otherwise.

Notes

1. Robin Middleton, "The Studio as Pedagogical Space," in *Design Education: Learning, Teaching, Thinking*, ed. Brian Garner (Bristol: Intellect Books, 2011), 45–58.
2. Andrew McGettigan, *The Great University Gamble: Money, Markets and the Future of Higher Education* (London: Pluto Press, 2013), 1–22.
3. Richard Sennett, *The Craftsman* (London: Allen Lane, 2008), 37–52.
4. Stefan Collini, *What Are Universities For?* (London: Penguin Books, 2012), 3–60.
5. John Dewey, *Experience and Education* (New York: Macmillan, 1938; repr., New York: Free Press, 1997), 25–48.
6. Martha C. Nussbaum, *Not for Profit: Why Democracy Needs the Humanities* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2010), 2–35.
7. Ron Barnett, *Realizing the University in an Age of Supercomplexity* (Buckingham: Society for Research into Higher Education and Open University Press, 2000), 6–22.
8. Sennett, *The Craftsman*, 147–176.

9. Liang, et al., "GPT Detectors Are Biased Against Non-Native English Writers," *Patterns* 4, no. 7 (2023): 100779. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.patter.2023.100779>.

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